The spin of “neighbourhood first” was to seek regional cooperation outside SAARC through subregionalism and other regional groupings. Accordingly, India took the initiative like the BBIN (Bhutan, Bangladesh, India and Nepal) Agreement on free movement of motor vehicles and started strengthening other regional groupings like the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC), which included Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, and Thailand. The idea was to keep Pakistan out, as that country had no place in either of these groupings. This suited Modi’s domestic political agenda as well, aimed at communal polarisation. In pursuit of such initiatives as well as to keep “neighbourhood first” relevant even without Pakistan, the salience of other neighbours in India’s approach got a boost. Accordingly, countries like Nepal, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka started receiving comparatively greater attention from India.

Policy on the ground

A strong underlying message of Modi’s new approach towards its neighbours was that *India cares but will engage on its own terms*. To convey the message that it cares, India moved in to bridge the contact and communication gap with neighbours and address their feeling that it was indifferent towards and neglectful of them in its policy priorities. The calling of neighbouring leaders to the swearing-in ceremony of the Prime Minister was the first symbolic but substantial step. This was followed by systematic visits at the high political levels by the Prime Minister and the Minister of External Affairs to the neighbouring countries.

These visits broke the long absence of visits and personal contacts from India’s side in the case of Nepal and Sri